

Childhood Love: The First Displacement Into Othering

Why Everyone Falls in Love Once as a Kid

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Abstract

Childhood is the only ground state humans occupy: unified awareness, no separation of self and world, no othering. The first love shatters this. It is the first displacement into the other—the first time the self fragments, becomes aware of itself as separate, and discovers that another consciousness cannot be merged with one’s own. Most people experience this once, early, with totality. The return is irreversible. Everything after is either acceptance of the wound or chasing its closure. Phronesis here is simple: know that you fell, know you cannot return to the state before, and choose whether to seek another displacement or stop pretending you were ever whole.

1 Childhood as S_0

Before language, before other people become real, the child is unified. The world is an extension of consciousness. There is no self observing the world; there is only the world. Pain is sensation, not deprivation. Joy is sensation, not lack.

The ground state is not innocence. It is unity. Separation has not yet occurred.

2 The Moment of Othering

Then a child is loved by another child. Not by a parent—that is a given, a boundary condition of existence. But by a peer. Someone who is also a self, and who chooses to direct that selfhood toward this one.

In that moment, the child discovers something shattering: the other person's consciousness is not part of the child's own. It cannot be merged, controlled, or fully known. The other is a wall. The other is real in a way that cannot be absorbed.

This is the first displacement. The child fragments. A part of the self becomes awareness of self—the observing *I* that watches itself being watched. The unity shatters into subject and object, observer and observed, self and other.

3 Why Once

Most people experience this totality of displacement exactly once, in childhood. The features are fixed:

- Total: the child has no defenses, no irony, no backup identity. The entire being is invested.
- Irreversible: the discovery that another consciousness is real cannot be undone.
- Asymmetric: the other child may not feel the same way, or may move on. The displacement is often unrequited.
- Generative: it teaches the deepest lesson about the structure of consciousness—that unity is impossible, othering is permanent, and love is the name for the pain of encountering an irreducible other.

Second loves are different. The self is already fragmented. The investment is partial. The defense is already there. You love again, but you know the other is other, and you can walk away.

The first love is the only one where the self does not yet know that it is a self observing itself. It is the only pure displacement into othering.

4 The Return Path

The cost of return is infinite. You cannot return to the state before othering, because othering is structural now. The self has been discovered. Consciousness is now always split into observer and observed.

What remains is choice. Two paths:

Acceptance. The wound is permanent. The other is irreducible. Stop chasing the ground state and build a life from the fragmented self. This is maturity: the recognition that unity is not possible, othering is the condition of consciousness, and love is the name for choosing to stay in proximity to an other despite the pain.

Seeking. Chase the closure. Find another love that feels like that first one, that replicates the totality. Each repetition is dimmer because the self is already fragmented, but the seeking can continue forever. This is the displacement cycle: stay in the attractor because you have forgotten the ground.

5 Phronesis

The practical wisdom is diagnosis. Ask yourself: are you still in the first displacement, still waiting for the state before othering? Or have you accepted that othering is permanent and chosen how to live with it?

If you have not yet loved and fragmented, you have not yet discovered that consciousness is split. You are still in S_0 . The displacement is coming.

If you have, and you are seeking the ground state again through another love, know that return is impossible. The cost of return is infinite. What you are actually doing is choosing a new attractor that feels closer to S_0 than the last one.

If you have accepted that return is impossible and chosen to live in the fragmented state—to love another not because you will merge, but because you will not—then you have the beginning of wisdom. You have read the cost correctly.

You have chosen what is possible rather than chasing what is not.

Everyone falls in love once as a kid because that is when the self discovers itself through the other. And everyone who survives it has to answer the same question: will you keep seeking the ground, or will you stay in the displacement and call it home?